



TOWN COUNCIL
HYBRID MEETING – VIRTUAL AND IN-PERSON
March 16, 2026
Regular Town Council Meeting
Council Chambers

UNAPPROVED MINUTES

1) CALL TO ORDER

Mayor Black-Burke called the meeting to order at 7:30 p.m.

Present: Mayor Nuchette Black-Burke, Deputy Mayor Darleen Klase, Councilor Mary Armstrong, Councilor James Durant, Councilor Ronald Eleveld, Councilor Kristin Gluck Hoffman, Councilor Anthony King, Councilor Ojala Naeem and Councilor William Pelkey

2) PRAYER REFLECTION

Councilor Pelkey led the group in prayer/reflection.

3) PLEDGE OF ALLEGIANCE

Councilor Pelkey led the group in the Pledge of Allegiance.

4) PROCLAMATIONS AND AWARDS

a) Recognizing Windsor Women for Women's History Month

Mayor Black-Burke opened by recognizing the Human Relations Commission's International Women's Day celebration, which honored three phenomenal women of Windsor: Maureen Canning, Josefina "Josie" Rodriguez, and Mel Madigan from the Bean.

The Mayor then recognized three women's organizations, the Windsor Woman's Club, the Windsor Junior Woman's Club and the League of Women Voters of North Central Connecticut which each received certificates of appreciation from the Town of Windsor and citations from the Connecticut House of Representatives presented by State Representative Jane Garibay.

The League of Women Voters of Windsor North Central Connecticut was recognized for their dedication to civic engagement, voter education, and strengthening the democratic process. The organization, founded in 1920 as an outgrowth of the suffragist movement, continues to help citizens carry out their voting responsibilities.

The Windsor Junior Women's Club was honored for encouraging involvement in charitable and civic activities while raising funds for local charities. The nonprofit organization provides women 18 and older various ways to serve the Windsor community while stimulating leadership qualities and exchanging ideas and friendship.

The Windsor Women's Club of Connecticut, federated in 1963, was celebrated for their extensive community service. In the past year alone, they donated items to Lucinda's House (the largest donation ever received), provided clothes and toiletries to Rocky Hills Veterans Hospital, made Valentine's Day cards for over 100 patients at Kimberly Hall. They will also host a tag vendor bake sale to support Windsor High School senior scholarships. Their 60 members continue to thrive in supporting the Windsor community.

Mayor Black-Burke also acknowledged the Windsor High School girls flag football team for making history by winning the first CCC girls flag football championship, establishing the foundation for girls flag football within the conference and Windsor Public Schools.

5) PUBLIC COMMUNICATIONS AND PETITIONS

Dr. Linda Alexander (155 Fieldstone Drive) expressed concerns about narrowing the road in Windsor Center, questioning whether it would create a shopping paradise or add inconvenience that motivates people to shop elsewhere. She noted that nearby towns are addressing safety through speed limit reductions and traffic light timing adjustments without major road reconstruction. Ms. Alexander warned that making drastic, irreversible changes could damage Windsor Center and predicted fewer people would find it attractive to shop if the road becomes narrower.

Teresa Bolkus-Bouthat (14 Parkwood Drive) opposed the road diet, explaining her 2025 vote was not just against rotaries but against narrowing from two lanes to one lane. She argued that safety issues require more enforcement of speed limits and driver education about yielding to pedestrians, rather than narrowing the street. Ms. Bouthat expressed concern about the proposed bike lanes, citing traffic safety data showing high percentages of cyclist fatalities from right-side impacts. She suggested if bike lanes are necessary, they should run from Batchelder Street to Mechanic Street to Central Avenue.

Jeanette Coffin (35 Hobson Avenue) supported Ms. Bouthat's concerns about bike lane safety design. Based on her research, she explained that the current layout placing bike lanes between moving traffic and parallel parking creates multiple risks. Ms. Coffin noted that optimal bicycle safety design places traffic, then parking, then bike lanes, then sidewalks, with barriers between bike lanes and parking to prevent door accidents and backing up incidents.

6) COMMUNICATIONS FROM COUNCIL MEMBERS

Mayor Black-Burke congratulated the phenomenal women of Windsor and expressed happiness to call Windsor home. She wished everyone a happy Saint Patrick's Day and extended Eid Mubarak to those concluding Ramadan celebrations.

Councilor Gluck-Hoffman praised the Shad Derby Gala showcasing outstanding young women in the community and thanked the Junior Women's Club for their Irish culture celebration at the Birdcage. She expressed gratitude to all three women's organizations, stating that without such clubs, she wouldn't be sitting on the Council.

Councilor Eleveld reported attending the Human Relations Commission's phenomenal women recognition event, which had better attendance than expected. He highlighted the Shad Derby bowling event where contestants had great camaraderie, and announced the Shad Derby kickoff at Back East Brewing this Friday, with tickets available on the Windsor Rotary website at a discount until Thursday.

Councilor Armstrong thanked the evening's honored women for their service and sacrifices to society. She noted seeing many residents out enjoying Windsor, shopping and walking dogs, and emphasized that the Council listens to and discusses public input whether received in person or virtually.

Councilor Pelkey reminded residents about the winter overnight parking ban still being in effect and encouraged community members to visit Windsor fire stations on Monday nights at 6:30 PM for tours and potential volunteer opportunities. He promoted visiting windsorfiredept.org for more information.

Deputy Mayor Klase promoted the Northwest Park Pancake Breakfast on Saturday starting at 8:00 AM, encouraging early arrival due to long lines. She also urged everyone to slow down due to recent accidents in town caused by speeding.

Councilor Naeem echoed the sentiment shared tonight and she congratulated the phenomenal woman of Windsor. It is, quite a group to be joining in. She was not able to attend, but heard it was a fantastic turnout. So happy to see that. It's incredible to see the roles that women play in this town and makes her even happier to call this town home. She wished everyone a Happy St. Patrick's Day. Happy Eid Mubarak to everyone that will be celebrating.

Councilor Durant expressed appreciation for witnessing democracy in action at recent meetings and encouraged public participation.

Councilor King thanked everyone for coming out and speaking and also just celebrating women's history Month.

7) REPORT OF APPOINTED BOARDS AND COMMISSIONS

a) Board of Ethics

Sonia Worrell-Asare, Member of Board of Ethics, gave the Board of Ethics report as follows:

Ms. Worrell-Asare stated at the request of the town manager, member of the Windsor Town Council, the superintendent of school or member of the Board of Education, the Board of Ethics renders advisory opinions concerning the actions of a town official or employee with respect to the Code of Ethics. The Board of Ethics meets quarterly. The Board of Ethics did not have any advisory opinions during the year of 2025.

During 2025, 2 meetings were cancelled due to a lack of quorum and 2 regular meetings were held.

b) Commission on Aging & Persons with Disabilities

Kathryn Roby, Member of the Commission on Aging & Persons with Disabilities gave the following report:

2025 Updates:

- One new member was added to the board which has helped with attaining a quorum during meetings.
- The activities/programs brochure was revised.
- A presentation was given on "Preparing for your 2025 AARP Tax appointment" and was well attended.
- The Senior/Social Services "Resource Manual" was updated with a new look. Copies were placed at town hall, both libraries, Social and Senior Services as well as distributed at the Commission's booth during the annual Senior Health & Wellness Fair.
- A display was created in the CVS window facing Broad Street which helped to increase awareness of the Commission activities. The display remained in the window from spring up through early summer.
- State Representative Jane Garibay returned to the Senior Center to provide an update on legislation that may affect older adults and people with disabilities.
- John Mills, a noted genealogist, gave a presentation and spoke about the growing interest in researching and reconstructing the personal histories of African American families.
- The Department of Advocacy for Aging and Disabled persons gave a presentation focused on services and support for at-risk individuals in the community, helping them remain safely in their homes.
- Other presentations were given to help enrich the community.

- A new focus area for the Commission is establishing or fostering existing relationships with Windsor High School, Loomis Chaffee and other groups to broaden the Commission's reach in the community. In example, Loomis Chaffee helped with the CVS window display and also helped with the law clean-up projects for seniors.

Ms. Roby went over the activities/programs that are planned for 2026.

Ms. Roby stated at the commission's last two meetings, discussion was raised regarding the Traffic Calming project. The commission is requesting that the pedestrian crosswalks which are currently set for 25-30 seconds on Broad Street be increased to a minimum of 60 seconds if possible.

c) Metropolitan District Commission

John Avedisian, gave a report for the Metropolitan District Commission highlighting their support for the February 28-March 1 Winter Special Olympics by donating up to 1,000,000 gallons of water for snow-making, with 500,000 gallons actually used. Windsor is the only Special Olympics location guaranteed snow every year.

- Collections update showed 692 shutoff notices totaling \$1,100,000 in delinquent balances across eight towns in 2026, with approximately \$379,000 (36%) collected.
- Operation Fuel assistance provided 44 grants totaling \$16,000 in Windsor during 2025, compared to only 7 grants for \$2,600 so far in 2026.
- Customer service improvements include a new mobile app for easier online bill payment.
- The MDC successfully negotiated water transfer agreements with Portland for up to 2,000,000 gallons per day, helping to keep prices stable. While ad valorem rates decreased in some towns, Windsor experienced a slight increase due to calculation methods, though overall pricing has remained consistent over four years.
- The MDC is pursuing legal action against Connecticut for approximately \$30,000,000 in owed landfill discharge fees, with the case currently in court.
- Drinking water reserves are at 95.1% of usable capacity (37,000,000 gallons) representing 631 days of supply.
- Sewage treatment operates at 37% capacity, having treated 52,000,000 gallons.

Commissioner Avedisian praised management and staff for accomplishing significant work with reduced personnel and noted prompt responses to resident complaints, including immediate road repairs on Pierson Lane following water main breaks.

8) TOWN MANAGER'S REPORT

Town Manager Souza stated the following:

2026 Neighborhood Assistance Act Proposals Welcome

Community non-profit organizations are welcomed to submit applications for the Connecticut Neighborhood Assistance Act (NAA), a State Tax Credit Program that provides funding for municipal and tax exempt organizations. Eligible programs include, but are not limited to: energy conservation, employment and training, child care services, neighborhood assistance, substance abuse, open space acquisition, and affordable housing development. For more information and application form, please visit the Community Development Neighborhood Assistance Act page at <https://www.windsorct.gov/247/2026-Neighborhood-Assistance-Act-Proposa> Applications are due by close of business day on May 19, 2026.

Informational Budget Meeting

An informational meeting on the town's annual budget process and the FY 2027 Town Manager's Proposed Budget will be held on Monday, March 30, 2026 at 6:30 PM at Town Hall. The public is invited to attend to learn about various elements of the budget process, including revenue sources, the wide range of town services and projects funded through the proposed FY 2027 budget.

Gizmo's Pawesome Guide to Mental Health

The Health Department is partnering with Clover Street and Kennedy elementary schools to provide Gizmo's Pawesome Guide to Mental Health read-alongs to all third graders. Read-alongs will be provided to each classroom and each student will receive a Gizmo's Pawesome Guide to Mental Health book as well as a plushie (small stuffed dog resembling Gizmo). These read-alongs are scheduled for March at John F Kennedy School and March and April for Clover Street School. Therapy dog visits with their handlers will follow later in March and the beginning of April.

Matianuck State Park & Windsor Wildlife Management Area Habitat Management

The Connecticut Department of Energy and Environmental Protection (DEEP) is planning to conduct a prescribed burn at a portion of the sand dune within the Matianuck Natural Area Preserve (NAP) and the Windsor Wildlife Management Area (WMA) in coming weeks weather permitting. The prescribed or controlled burn is an effective way to sustain and enhance the wildlife habitat.

DEEP Wildlife Division last conducted a prescribed burn in these areas in spring 2024 that was safe and successful. Their plan is to conduct a prescribed fire over sections of the grassy sand dune located at the center of preserves.

The Fire Department and Fire Marshal's Office have been contacted by CT DEEP.

Northwest Park Pancake Breakfast

Join the Friends of Northwest Park for the 39th Annual Pancake Breakfast on Saturday, March 21, 2026, from 8:00 AM to 11:00 AM.

After breakfast, explore the Sugar House to see how maple syrup is made, visit the nature center, tobacco museum, and animal barn, or take a leisurely walk on the park's scenic trails.

Tickets are \$6.00 for adults, \$4.00 for children under 12, and free for children 3 and under; please note this is a cash-only event. All proceeds benefit projects at Northwest Park. For more information, call Northwest Park at 285-1886.

9) REPORTS OF STANDING COMMITTEES

Town Improvements Committee – Deputy Mayor Klase provided an extensive Town Improvement Committee report on their well-attended meeting focused primarily on the road diet proposal. She summarized arguments from both sides:

Opposition concerns included:

- The 2025 referendum defeat, side street traffic congestion, highway accident backup impacts, preference to wait until downtown apartments and vacant businesses are full, bike lane safety issues, lack of current bikers downtown, absence of perceived current safety issues, reliance on old studies, and insufficient discussion.

Support arguments emphasized:

- Existing safety dangers for pedestrians and bikers, dangerous vehicle speeds, potential for encouraging downtown vibrancy, thorough study basis, sound engineering principles, business enhancement benefits, public support, and walking perspective advantages.

The next steps include a planned public forum, public comment, council consideration, and if approved, a special town meeting at a larger venue with organized ballot voting to accommodate expected larger crowds.

Finance Committee – Councilor Naeem announced an upcoming Finance Committee meeting on March 24th at 6:30 PM and indicated she would share information from previous discussions later in the meeting.

Health and Safety Committee – Councilor Armstrong – nothing to report.

Joint Town Council/Board of Education Committee – Deputy Mayor Klase - nothing to report.

Personnel Committee – Councilor King – nothing to report.

10) ORDINANCES – None

11) UNFINISHED BUSINESS

- a) Approve an ordinance entitled, "AN ORDINANCE APPROPRIATING \$885,000 FOR COSTS IN CONNECTION WITH MAIN HALLWAY RESTROOMS RENOVATION AT L.P. WILSON COMMUNITY CENTER/BOARD OF EDUCATION OFFICES; AND AUTHORIZING THE ISSUE OF \$885,000 BONDS AND NOTES TO FINANCE THE APPROPRIATION."

RESOLVED by Deputy Mayor Klase, seconded by Councilor Naeem that the reading into the minutes of the text of the bond ordinance entitled, "AN ORDINANCE APPROPRIATING \$885,000 FOR COSTS IN CONNECTION WITH MAIN HALLWAY RESTROOMS RENOVATION AT L.P. WILSON COMMUNITY CENTER/BOARD OF EDUCATION OFFICES; AND AUTHORIZING THE ISSUE OF \$885,000 BONDS AND NOTES TO FINANCE THE APPROPRIATION" is hereby waived, the full text of the ordinance having been distributed to each member of the Council and copies being made available to those persons attending this meeting; and that the full text of the ordinance be recorded with the minutes of this meeting

Motion Passed 9-0-0

MOVED by Deputy Mayor Klase, seconded by Councilor Eleveld to approve a bond ordinance entitled, "AN ORDINANCE APPROPRIATING \$885,000 FOR COSTS IN CONNECTION WITH MAIN HALLWAY RESTROOMS RENOVATION AT L.P. WILSON COMMUNITY CENTER/BOARD OF EDUCATION OFFICES; AND AUTHORIZING THE ISSUE OF \$885,000 BONDS AND NOTES TO FINANCE THE APPROPRIATION."

Town Manager Souza confirmed availability to answer questions, noting the ordinance was subject to the previous presentation and this evening's public hearing.

Councilor Pelkey inquired about assumed interest rates. Town Manager Souza responded that bond interest rates are around 5% while current investment returns on cash are between 3.5-4%.

Motion Passed 9-0-0

12) NEW BUSINESS

- a) Approve an appropriation of \$80,000 from the Capital Projects Fund for the Day Hill Road pavement Management design project

MOVED by Deputy Mayor Klase, seconded by Councilor Naeem, to approve an appropriation of \$80,000 from the Capital Projects Fund Assigned Fund Balance for design services related to the Day Hill Road (Marshall Phelps to Baker Hollow Road) Rehabilitation project.

Suzanne Choate, Town Engineer, stated the town's most recent pavement evaluations indicate this section of Day Hill Road is in fair to poor condition, with a Road Surface Rating (RSR) as low as 41 (on a scale of 100) on parts of the roadway. Linear pavement cracking and raveling are visible in the pavement as well as rutting in the intersections. The scope of design services will include survey, geotechnical investigation, engineering, and construction plans and specifications. Project design is anticipated to be complete by the end of the calendar year. The adopted CIP includes construction funding in FY 27. At this time, staff is requesting \$80,000 for design services.

Councilor Eleveld asked about geotechnical investigation. Ms. Choate explained it involves borings and analysis of existing pavement structure to determine subsurface conditions.

Motion Passed 9-0-0

b) Discussion of Local Option Homestead Exemption

Councilor Naeem presented information on the Local Option Homestead Exemption, a state legislative option from 2024 allowing municipalities to exempt 5-35% of assessed value from property taxes for owner-occupied residences of no more than two units. While this could reduce homeowner taxes, the revenue must be made up through other sources including commercial properties, motor vehicles, and personal property taxes.

The Finance Committee brought this forward for full Council discussion after public concerns last year, though they made no recommendation to adopt it. No public comments were received on this topic either at the Finance Committee meeting or during public comment periods.

Councilor Eleveld provided a detailed explanation of the tax burden shift implications, noting that while homeowners might see assessed value reductions, mill rates would increase to maintain revenue, potentially affecting vehicle taxes and creating perceived anti-business impacts. He expressed his concern about being among the first towns to implement this effort without understanding practical effects, noting only New Milford recently adopted it for their new fiscal year.

Councilor Pelkey found the concept interesting as a potential tool during revaluation years when burden shifts occur. He also emphasized the need for more consideration time and broader public discussion.

Councilor Naeem clarified this was intended as discussion rather than action, noting that any budget impact decision would need to occur before fiscal year 2027 budget development. She expressed personal skepticism about the exemption as a poorly thought-out band-aid for regressive local tax system issues, preferring comprehensive solutions over temporary fixes that could be withdrawn by the legislature.

Councilor Eleveld noted nationwide trends toward office return policies that might improve commercial real estate values in future revaluations. Councilor Naeem clarified there are no plans to bring this back to Finance Committee before budget meetings unless strong council interest emerges.

c) Approve collective bargaining agreement with Teamsters Local 671

MOVED by Deputy Mayor Klase, seconded by Councilor King to approve the collective bargaining agreement between the Town of Windsor and Teamsters Local 671 for the period of July 1, 2025 through June 30, 2028.

Human Resources Director, Amelia Bliss, provided comprehensive details on the negotiated agreement with the public works and clerical bargaining unit. Negotiations centered on wages, health insurance, leave benefits, and operational contract language, including union proposal to decertify clerical positions so Teamsters would represent only public works-related positions.

The agreement was ratified unanimously by the bargaining unit with 100% voter turnout and runs retroactively from July 1, 2025 through June 30, 2028.

Key provisions include transition to Teamsters Silver PPO health plan effective May 1, 2026, providing lower premiums, reduced copays, fixed premiums through 2028, and union-handled enrollment and customer service. Employee contributions remain at 22.5% with the town contributing 77.5%.

Wage increases average 2.92% over three years: 3% effective July 1, 2025 (retroactive), 3% effective July 1, 2026, and 2.85% effective July 1, 2027. Market adjustments of 1.89% to 5% were negotiated for positions below market 50th percentile, effective May 1, 2026, funded through current vacancy savings.

Eight clerical positions will be decertified effective May 1, 2026, transferring to administration pay plan with largely unchanged benefits and merit-based wage increases.

Other notable changes include improved vacation accrual for employees hired after July 1, 2008, year-round summer hours (7 AM to 3 PM with 20-minute on-site lunch), reduced vacation accrual cessation during disability leave from 6 to 4 months, increased sick leave for new hires from 40 to 80 hours annually, documented maintainer promotion language, biweekly payroll authorization, and codified retiree Medicare health insurance practices.

Financial impacts include \$24,000 in FY 2026 market adjustment costs funded through salary savings, \$257,860 FY 2027 increases for wages, steps and market adjustments, \$98,589 FY 2028 increases, and approximately \$268,350 in avoided FY 2027 health insurance costs.

Town Manager Souza noted negotiations were prolonged due to decertification issues requiring state labor board review, which ultimately determined it was a negotiable item. He praised both negotiating teams and explained that aggressive 2008 benefit changes weren't adopted by comparable towns, creating recruitment and retention challenges that this agreement addresses.

Councilor Pelkey inquired about ratification vote details. Ms. Bliss confirmed it was a unanimous approval with unprecedented 100% turnout.

Motion Passed 9-0-0

13) RESIGNATIONS AND APPOINTMENTS - None

14) MINUTES OF PRECEDING MEETINGS

a) Minutes of the March 2, 2026 Public Hearing meeting

MOVED by Deputy Mayor Klase, seconded by Councilor Gluck Hoffman to approve the minutes of the March 2, 2026 Public Hearing meeting as presented.

Motion Passed 9-0-0

b) Minutes of the March 2, 2026 Regular meeting

MOVED by Deputy Mayor Klase, seconded by Councilor Gluck Hoffman to approve the minutes of the March 2, 2026 Regular Town Council meeting as presented.

Motion Passed 9-0-0

15) PUBLIC COMMUNICATIONS AND PETITIONS - None

16) EXECUTIVE SESSION - None

17) ADJOURNMENT

MOVED by Mayor Black-Burke, seconded by Councilor Armstrong to adjourn the meeting at 9:13 p.m.

Motion Passed 9-0-0

Respectfully Submitted,



Regular Town Council meeting
March 16, 2026

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Helene M. Albert
Recording Secretary